

source, and similarly, open source software need not be free either. A free, but not open source, software can only be used, but cannot be modified—or for that matter dissected to see how it works. Open source software can also be *paid* software, in which the source code is made available to the buyer. Open source and free software are closely related in the Linux world, but they are not the same.

The idea of free software or open source is in fact older than that of commercial (paid) software. Computers were first used for academic and research purposes; software programmers were paid for their efforts and their programming skills, but *not* for the programs themselves. In other words, once the software was written, it was the property of the user and not of the developer.

But when computers reached banks and large establishments, the earliest software companies and programmers saw a huge potential for making money. Software, though not a physical entity, attained the status of a product. Software writers began to charge the users for every copy of the software deployed. Thus the software ownership began to rest with the programmers, and this led to the “paid software” concept. This idea seems simple. If you design a car and sell it, you charge for every car you sell. This is not only for the cost of materials but also because anyone who uses the car owes you something for your ideas and skills. (Well, in software, there is no material cost for each copy—and that’s an argument that open source / free software advocates put forward.) Software that was once the property of the user is now largely the property of the maker. Some analysts believe that this will come full circle and that the trend again will be towards open source.

No discussion on open source or free software is complete without the mention of Richard Stallman, the founder of the GNU project, who has written numerous books and white papers on open source. His *Free Software as a Political Idea* is one concept and ideology that has inspired the open source world. He designed a set of rights that he feels all users are entitled to. These have been